

Need Assessment Report

Childcare Services
for
Low-paid Working Parents and Other Stakeholders

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Phulki

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Executive Summary

This need assessment study was undertaken by Phulki, as a step to assess the need for daycare centers in Dhaka and Gazipur cities where a large number of industries, specially the garment industries, have been established. The aim of the study is to find the opinions of the parents (garment employees) and other stakeholders regarding daycare center (DCC) facilities for their child safety in their communities. The study discussed other related issues of the direct and indirect financial involvement of the communities and other stakeholders from the sample.

The objectives of the study are to:

- identify need for a safe secure stimulating and enabling environment for children to the urban slum/community people;
- assess the need for daycare services to the local government and community elites;
- assess the perceptions of factory management about childcare services; and to
- identify the demand for daycare centers for the government and corporate officials.

This study has followed the 'Cross sectional study design'. Considering the reality, a blend of methods (questionnaire survey and in-depth interview with key informants) has been adapted. The primary source of information was the parents of children in two slums of Dhaka (Mirpur and Uttara) and three slums of Gazipur. In total, 500 parents were targeted, and finally 481 were interviewed. The number of key informants was 70 including officials of public and private sectors, elected representatives of the local government, and local elites.

From the study, it was found that a significant number of the respondents are the women of 27.66 years of age, which is considered the reproductive age. Most of them are poor or semi-poor due to an average monthly income of Tk. 9,135. To maintain the minimum living standard, however, they are unable to leave this job. Besides, it empowered them in terms of control over income, and made them self-reliant.

Each respondent has at least one child and maximum six. Among the respondents, 86% have children with age up to six. Most of the children live alone or with others when the respondents are at work.

Daycare center is a new concept. Around 50% respondents have not heard the name of it. After describing the functions of the DCC, about 90% respondents agreed that DCC is helpful for their children's development.

The respondents who keep their children in the DCCs have acknowledged that the DCCs have a positive impact on their child's development. The centers can impact on child development because they take better care, are well organized, have better learning environment where the children can learn from one another, and ensure joyful environment for the children. The DCCs are empowering as they help the working women and as they help the women to increase their income.

Many of the working women have small children. They have to depend on domestic helps to look after their kids while they are on office. Therefore, it is necessary to set up adequate number of quality daycare centres both at government and private levels so that women can get to work without concern for their infants.

However, in our study we find that a significant number of women are of reproductive age. In absence of a daycare center, a large number of women have leave or at least pause in their job. This would not be benefitting for the entrepreneurs as well as economy.

The private and public sectors can establish and operate the DCCs in their office premises at minimum costs. For example, an industry where the total number of female workers is 625 established it at Tk. 100,000. Another industry where the total number of female workers is around 3,500 set up a center at Tk. 300,000. The operational cost per month is Tk. 30,000 and Tk. 60,000 respectively.

A partnership between entrepreneurs and workers can ensure essential support for the development of children as well as increase in productivity of the industry. According to **Article 28 .1 of UNCRC** State parties recognize the right of the child to education, and with a view to achieving this right progressively and on the basis of equal opportunity. To enforce rules and regulations regarding DCC in the workplace, the government should step up its monitoring, increase the number of DCCs to fulfill the commitment to child development.